

The Teachings of Silvanus

Codex Reference: VII,4

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced and translated by Malcolm L. Peel and Jan Zandee

The eclectic spirit of the second and early third centuries is clearly reflected in the fourth tractate of Codex VII, The Teachings of Silvanus. Its author, like other educated Christians, found it necessary both to reject erroneous pagan thought and yet, simultaneously, to appropriate the best of such thought to clarify and make cogent the Faith. The resultant text, a rare specimen of Hellenistic Christian wisdom literature, displays a remarkable synthesis of biblical and late Jewish ideas with Middle Platonic and late Stoic anthropological, ethical, and theological concepts. The synthesis has a didactic purpose: to impart the wisdom of Christ which confers the self-controlled and "quiet" life, enables one to be "pleasing to" the Divine, and, ultimately, helps one "become like God."

Unlike the other four tractates in Codex VII, Teach. Silv. is not gnostic and may even contain some anti-gnostic polemic. It is explicitly affirmed, for example, that all creation has been brought into being by God through his "hand," the Christ. Thus, unlike the gnostic dualists, one should never describe the Creator (demiurge!) as "ignorant," in spite of the author's pessimism regarding interpersonal relations (97,30-98,10). Moreover, instead of a docetic view of Christ, the author states that the Savior "bore affliction" for our sins, "died" as a "ransom" and gave his life for others, and put on "humanity." With respect to anthropology, while the author does espouse a tripartite view of man ("mind," "soul," and "body") similar to the gnostic, he departs sharply from their views that one is "saved by nature." Every human being, the text maintains, possesses both divine "reason" and "mind" and thus has the capacity for salvation; God wishes for all to be saved.

Perhaps what helped attract the Teach. Silv. to the predominantly gnostic collection of writings that constitute the Nag Hammadi library, however, was its rather austere and somewhat ascetic ethic. The text counsels keeping under control base passions, passions and unclean thoughts which are induced by the adversary, Satan. One is to have God alone as a friend, for all the world is deceitful and full of pain. Moreover, "austerity" is a type of life to be preferred, and "fornication" is to be avoided rigorously, as is "lust." Especially must one struggle with Satan, the adversary, who offers temptations in subtle disguises, and whose evil powers seek to infest one's life. Such an ascetic and almost "anchoritic" ethic could have appealed to Gnostics, as could also other concepts in the text, such as the "bridal chamber" in 94,27-29.

The literary genre of Teach. Silv. is clearly indebted to Jewish and Hellenistic Jewish wisdom literature; though the author is also influenced by the Cynic-Stoic diatribe and the Hellenistic hymn styles. Influence from the Jewish side, though, is exhibited in the direct quotes in Teach. Silv. of canonical and apocryphal (e.g., 112,37-113,7 = Wis 7:25-26) wisdom writings.

With respect to content, the first part of Teach. Silv. is more Hellenistic and philosophical in character. The latter part is more specifically Christian and biblical in imagery.

In the initial part (84,15-99,4) the writer's main concern is with the state of the soul. To prevent its being inhabited and overcome by base passions and irrational impulses (symbolically described as "robbers" and "wild, savage beasts"), the reader is admonished to let the "mind" (nous) become his "guiding principle" and "reason" (logos) become his "teacher." The terminology and emphases clearly echo the anthropology and ethics of the late Stoa and of Middle Platonism.

In the second part of the tractate (99,6-118,7), on the other hand, emphasis is placed on the salvation of the soul made possible by the Redeemer-Revealer Christ, Son of Almighty God. At the outset, the author echoes the Platonic discussion of the "One and the many," utilizing this concept to discuss how Christ and God, like the "mind" in man's body, is present all places without being confined to a single place. Such "topological theology" both presupposes a nondualistic cosmology in rather anti-gnostic fashion and offers an implicit refutation of the pantheistic theology of Stoicism. In conclusion, the reader is exhorted to seek Christ's inward help in illuminating "reason," in escaping the control of evil powers, in purifying one's life, and in seeking the lasting rewards of his wisdom and God's way (117,5-118,7).

As to the authorship of Teach. Silv., we know of several early prominent Christians who bore the name "Silvanus." The late dates of their activity, however, and the differences of their teaching from that of our tractate seem to rule out consideration of any of them as its author. Rather, we are probably to recognize in the name "Silvanus" that common device used in Christian apocryphal literature of attributing a later, anonymous writing to a figure known by name in the New Testament canon. Such a "Silas" or "Silvanus" was a prominent member of the Jerusalem Church, cotraveller with Paul (Ac 15:22-40; 16:19-29; etc.), and possibly the amanuensis of "Peter's" named in 1 Peter 5:12. So, here is yet another Nag Hammadi tractate identified with the circle of influence emanating from Paul and Peter (cf. Pr. Paul, Apoc. Paul, Acts Pet., 12 Apost., Apoc. Pet. and Ep. Pet. Phil.). As to who the author of Teach. Silv. actually was, however, we must state (as did Origen of the author of Hebrews) "in truth (only) God knows!"

In dating the text, we are mainly dependent on internal evidence, though dates have been found in the cartonnage used to strengthen the leather envelope that contained Codex VII. These dates point toward the third quarter of the fourth century as the probable time of the manuscript's burial near ancient Chenoboskia. Internal evidence includes the author's apparent knowledge of all major divisions of Old and New Testament canons; the stage of development of the Church's doctrine of Christ's "Descent into Hell" that was familiar to the author; the affinities of the text's "Logos" and "Wisdom" Christology to that of the Alexandrine Fathers, Clement of Alexandria and Origen; and the close parallels of the thought of the later Stoa (notably, Marcus Aurelius) and Middle Platonists (especially Albinus) with that of the author of Teach. Silv. Cumulatively, such evidence points toward the late second to early third century.

Many striking parallels that can be adduced to our text from Philo, Sent. Sextus, Clement of Alexandria, Origen, and even Athanasius underscore its affinities with what has become known as Alexandrian theology. Its theology, Christology, cosmology, anthropology, and ethics all point, in their similarity, toward Alexandrian Egypt as the probable provenance.

The concluding note (118,8-9) is secondary, probably added by the copyist. It is surrounded by magical signs related to Christ's designation as "ichthys" ("fish"), an acrostic signifying "Jesus Christ, Son of God, Savior." It may well have been added by the copyist in response to the impressive Christology he has just copied in the text. For him Christ is truly the "extraordinary wonder"!